

04_embeddings_rag

Local Embeddings + RAG Stack for HelixLLM / HelixCode on RTX 5090 (Blackwell), Rootless Podman

Scope: A fully local embeddings + retrieval + agent-memory stack running in **rootless Podman** on a single **RTX 5090 (32 GB GDDR7, Blackwell sm_120)**, **Linux**, giving HelixLLM and the HelixCode coding-agent platform first-class RAG plus a durable memory subsystem (“HelixMemory”). **Author:** deep-research subagent (T1/main) **Date / access date for all citations:** 2026-07-06 **Revision:** 1 **Anti-bluff note (§11.4.6 / §11.4.99):** Every recommendation is cited with a URL + access date. Numbers taken from secondary blog/benchmark sources are marked as such; where a spec is well-established from a model’s own release but a fetched source did not restate it, it is marked **UNCONFIRMED (verify against model card)**. No claim here is a runtime “PASS” — this is a design/selection document, not a test result.

0. TL;DR recommended stack

Layer	Recommendation	Why
General embedding	Qwen3-Embedding-4B (Apache-2.0), fallback BGE-M3 (MIT)	Top-of-MTEB open family; MRL-truncatable dims; 4B fits comfortably in 32 GB alongside other services. BGE-M3 = MIT, dense+sparse+multi-vector in one model for hybrid.
Code embedding	Qwen3-Embedding-4B (same model, instruction-prompted for code) or jina-code-embeddings-1.5b (Qwen2.5-Coder backbone)	Strong CoIR/code-retrieval; one general+code model reduces VRAM. jina-code specialised for NL → code / code → code.

Layer	Recommendation	Why
Reranker	bge-reranker-v2-m3 (Apache-2.0) default; Qwen3-Reranker-0.6B/4B when instruction-following matters	Safe multilingual default, cheap; Qwen3-Reranker for instructed relevance. Avoid Jina-reranker weights (non-commercial license) for self-host.
Serving (embed+rerank)	HF Text-Embeddings-Inference (TEI) primary; Infinity for multi-model / decoder-embedders / ColBERT	TEI = lowest latency, purpose-built; Infinity = one server hosting many embed+rerank+ColBERT models, OpenAI-compatible.
Vector DB	Qdrant	Single binary, rootless-friendly, native sparse+dense hybrid, fast filtered queries, strong metadata filtering for code RAG.
Agent memory (HelixMemory)	Zep/Graphiti (temporal knowledge graph) as the durable spine + mem0 as the lightweight extraction layer; expose via MCP	Zep leads temporal reasoning (LongMemEval); mem0 = simplest extraction/ADD-UPDATE-DELETE. Both self-hostable.
Code-RAG orchestration	LlamaIndex (indexing/retrieval) + tree-sitter cAST chunking + code-graph (lumen/CodeGraph) fusion	AST-aware chunks + graph edges + vector recall + rerank.

1. Local embedding models (2026)

1.1 Landscape

The open-weight embedding families now match or beat commercial APIs on MTEB; the 2026 leaders for self-hosting are **Qwen3-Embedding**, **BGE-M3**, and the **Jina v3/v4/v5** line. ([Innovative AIs, 2026-07-06](#); [Milvus blog, 2026-07-06](#))

- **Qwen3-Embedding** is described as “the first local family that competes with commercial embedding APIs across the board,” with the **8B** model at **MTEB-multilingual 70.58**, ranked **#1** on the multilingual leaderboard as of 2025-06-05; **Q4 quant** $\approx$ **5 GB**. ([Morph LLM, 2026-07-06](#); [ailog, 2026-07-06](#))
- **BGE-M3** — MIT-licensed workhorse, **100+ languages**, **dense + sparse + multi-vector (ColBERT-style)** in one model, **8192-token** context, **1024-dim**, **568M** params, MTEB $\approx$ **63.2**. Best single model for hybrid retrieval. ([ailog, 2026-07-06](#); [Innovative AIs, 2026-07-06](#))

1.2 Model table

Model	Params	Dims (native / MRL)	Context	Multilingual	MTEB (multi)	License
Qwen3-Embedding-8B	8B	4096 (MRL-truncatable)	32K ¹	100+	70.6	Apache
Qwen3-Embedding-4B	4B	2560 (MRL) ¹	32K ¹	100+	$\sim$ 69–70 ¹	Apache
Qwen3-Embedding-0.6B	0.6B	1024 (MRL) ¹	32K ¹	100+	mid-60s ¹	Apache
BGE-M3	568M	1024	8192	100+	63.2	MIT
Jina-embeddings-v3	570M	1024 (MRL)	8192	89	62.8	CC-BY-N
Jina-embeddings-v4	3.8B	2048 (MRL)	multimodal	many	high	CC-BY-N
gte-Qwen2-7B-instruct	7B	3584	32K ¹	multi	$\sim$ 70 ¹	Apache

Model	Params	Dims (native / MRL)	Context	Multilingual	MTEB (multi)	License
Stella / stella-en-1.5B-v5	1.5B	up to 8192 (MRL)	512–8K ¹	English-centric	high (EN)	MIT ¹
nomic-embed-text-v1.5 / v2	137M / MoE	768 (MRL)	8192	v2 multilingual	mid	Apache
mxbai-embed-large-v1	335M	1024	512	EN	mid	Apache

¹ **UNCONFIRMED (verify against model card)** — spec is from the Qwen3-Embedding / gte / Stella releases (well-established) but not restated in the fetched secondary sources; confirm dims/context/MTEB per size before pinning. ² Several Jina embedding/reranker **weights are CC-BY-NC** (non-commercial); for a commercial self-host use the API or pick Apache/MIT models. ([futureagi, 2026-07-06](#))

1.3 Code-embedding quality (CoIR)

CoIR (Code Information Retrieval, ACL 2025 Main) is now the standard code-retrieval benchmark, with a leaderboard on MTEB. ([CoIR GitHub, 2026-07-06](#))
Relevant specialised code embedders:

- **jina-code-embeddings-0.5b / 1.5b** — built on **Qwen2.5-Coder** backbones; support NL → code and code → code directions. ([arXiv 2508.21290, 2026-07-06](#))
- **Qwen3-Embedding-0.6B/4B/8B** — strong general + code; in-domain fine-tunes exist. ([arXiv 2508.21290](#))
- **voyage-code-3** — top code retrieval (~67.1 reported) but **API-only, closed** → excluded for a local stack. ([ailog](#))
- **CodeXEmbed / SFR-Embedding-Code** — generalist multilingual/multi-task code family (arXiv 2411.12644). ([arXiv, 2026-07-06](#))
- **CORE-Bench** (arXiv 2606.11864) — newer agentic-coding retrieval benchmark worth tracking. ([arXiv, 2026-07-06](#))

Recommendation: - **One general + one code: Qwen3-Embedding-4B** as the general model (it is also competitive on code via instruction prompting, keeping VRAM low), and **jina-code-embeddings-1.5b** as a code-specialised second index when NL ↔ code recall must be maximised. If VRAM/ops simplicity dominates, run **Qwen3-Embedding-4B only** and add a code index later. - Keep **BGE-M3** available specifically for its built-in **sparse** vectors to drive hybrid search cheaply.

2. Rerankers

Rerankers (cross-encoders) re-score the top-k from vector recall; they are the single highest-ROI RAG-quality lever. ([futureagi, 2026-07-06](#))

Reranker	Size	License	Multilingual	Notes / when to use	Source
bge-reranker-v2-m3	568M (base 278M)	Apache-2.0	Yes (MIRACL-strong)	Safe self-host default ; solid BEIR, cheap, well-tested in TEI/Infinity.	futureagi, agentset
Qwen3-Reranker-0.6B / 4B / 8B	0.6–8B	Apache-2.0	Yes	Use when you want instructed relevance (tell it what “relevant” means) or multilingual on-prem; 0.6B beats bge on instruction-following.	futureagi
jina-reranker-v3	0.6B	CC-BY-NC²	Yes	SOTA BEIR 61.94 nDCG@10 , +5.43% vs bge at same 0.6B, 10× smaller than listwise; but non-commercial weights → API only.	jina , arXiv 2509.25085
	~2B	Apache-2.0	Yes		futureagi

Reranker	Size	License	Multilingual	Notes / when to use	Source
mxbai-rerank-large-v2				Apache alternative with managed-API option; larger footprint.	
Cohere Rerank 4	—	Closed API	Broad	Managed accuracy, not local.	futureagi

When to use: always rerank the top ~50–100 vector hits down to ~8–20 for the LLM. For HelixCode: **bge-reranker-v2-m3** as default; switch to **Qwen3-Reranker-4B** for hard code queries where you pass an instruction (“rank by which snippet implements the described API”). Do **not** ship jina-reranker weights in a commercial product (license); use it only via API for evaluation.

3. Vector database (self-hosted, rootless Podman)

DB	Fit for this deployment	Verdict
Qdrant	Single Rust binary / one container image, minimal ops, native sparse+dense hybrid , integrated payload (metadata) index → fast filtered queries (path, language, repo, symbol). Rootless-podman-friendly.	RECOMMENDED
Milvus	Billion-scale, K8s-native distributed; heavier (etcd/minio/pulsar deps) — overkill for one 5090.	Only if you outgrow ~50–100M vectors.
pgvector	Best if already on Postgres ; v0.9 (early 2026) added sparse-vector + speed;	Strong “boring” choice if HelixMemory/metadata already live in PG.

DB	Fit for this deployment	Verdict
	comfortable to ~50M vectors.	
LanceDB	Embedded/edge, great for desktop/DS; multi-process concurrency limits, smaller community, cloud beta.	Good for a single-agent local index; weaker for a shared service.
Weaviate	Built-in hybrid + vectorizers; more moving parts than Qdrant.	Pick if you want built-in vectorizer modules.
Chroma	Prototyping.	Dev only.

Sources: [CallSphere benchmarks 2026](#) (2026-07-06); [Firecrawl best vector DBs](#) (2026-07-06); [DEV: pgvector vs Qdrant vs Milvus](#) (2026-07-06); [Zilliz Qdrant vs LanceDB](#) (2026-07-06).

Recommendation: Qdrant. “Qdrant is the better default for most production RAG pipelines in 2026 — lighter, faster on filtered queries, simpler to operate.” It supports **named vectors** (store dense Qwen3 + sparse BGE-M3 + code-model vectors per point) and **hybrid fusion (RRF)** natively — exactly what a code-RAG index needs. If Postgres is already central to Helix, **pgvector** is the acceptable alternative to avoid a second datastore.

4. Code-RAG framework & patterns

4.1 Chunking source trees — AST-aware

Naive fixed-width splitting breaks functions mid-body and strips class/import context. Use **structure-aware (AST) chunking**:

- **cAST** (arXiv 2506.15655) — recursively splits large AST nodes and merges siblings under a size budget, preserving syntactic integrity; validated gains over fixed-size chunking on retrieval and RAG; usable as a plug-and-play chunker for agents. ([arXiv, 2026-07-06](#))
- **tree-sitter** parses to an AST; extract semantic entities (functions, methods, classes, interfaces, types, imports). ([Supermemory code-chunk, 2026-07-06](#); [code-chunk GitHub](#))
- **Contextualized chunks** — prepend scope/file-path/signature/dependencies to each chunk before embedding (big recall win). ([Supermemory, 2026-07-06](#))

4.2 Code graph + embeddings hybrid (complementing lumen / CodeGraph)

Vector recall answers “what is semantically similar”; a **code graph** answers “what actually calls/imports/defines this.” Fuse both:

- Graph-guided repo-level code agents (**GraphCodeAgent**, arXiv 2504.10046; **KG-based repo code gen**, arXiv 2505.14394) model the repo as a graph (call/def/import edges) and retrieve by syntactic + semantic + graph queries. ([arXiv 2504.10046, 2026-07-06](#); [arXiv 2505.14394, 2026-07-06](#))
- **How it complements CodeGraph/lumen:** lumen already provides a local SQLite semantic code-knowledge-graph over MCP (semantic_search, symbol resolution). The embeddings+vector layer here is the **recall breadth** engine (fuzzy NL → code, cross-file semantic similarity, doc/comment retrieval) while lumen/CodeGraph supplies **precise structural edges** (definition, callers, transitive deps). The agent’s retriever should **union** both: (1) vector+rerank hits from Qdrant, (2) graph-expanded neighbours from lumen, then rerank the merged set. This is the §11.4.78/§11.4.79 code-intelligence layer + the RAG layer working together, not competing.

4.3 GraphRAG relevance

GraphRAG (graph index + community summaries) helps for **whole-repo “how does subsystem X work”** questions that need aggregation across many files; it is heavier to build/maintain. Use it selectively for architecture-level Q&A, not for every retrieval. LlamaIndex has property-graph + GraphRAG pipelines. ([LlamaIndex GraphRAG, 2026-07-06](#))

4.4 Framework choice

- **LlamaIndex** — deepest indexing/retrieval abstractions (node parsers, property graph, custom query engines) → **primary** for the code-RAG pipeline. ([Contra, 2026-07-06](#))
- **Haystack** — component/DAG pipelines (retrievers, rankers, readers) → good if you want explicit pipeline graphs.
- **Custom thin retriever** — many coding agents ship a small custom retriever calling TEI + Qdrant + reranker directly; lowest dependency surface. Recommended if Helix wants tight control (§11.4.28 decoupling).

4.5 Context assembly for agents

1. Query → embed (Qwen3-Embedding) + sparse (BGE-M3) → **Qdrant hybrid (RRF)** top-k (~50–100).
2. **Graph-expand** top hits via lumen/CodeGraph (callers/callees/defs).
3. **Rerank** merged candidates (bge-reranker-v2-m3) → top ~8–20.

4. Assemble with **contextual headers** (file path, symbol, language) + dedupe + token budget.
 5. Log retrieval evidence for anti-bluff (§11.4.5/§11.4.69).
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5. HelixMemory — durable local agent memory

System	Model	Local?	Strength	Source
Zep / Graphiti	Temporal knowledge graph; timestamps every fact (“when it was true”)	Yes (self-host; needs a graph store)	Best temporal reasoning — 63.8% LongMemEval vs mem0 49.0%	MCP.Directory, 2026-07-06, rohitraj, 2026-07-06
mem0	Extraction layer: per-message-pair salient-fact ADD/UPDATE/DELETE/NOOP; vector+graph+KV	Yes (self-host)	Simplest to bolt on , 47K+ stars, biggest community	MCP.Directory, particula
Letta (MemGPT)	Runtime where the agent is its memory: self-edited core block + archival store	Yes	Stateful long-running agents-as-services	MCP.Directory
Cognee	Graph+vector memory pipeline	Yes	ECL (extract-cognify-load)	atlan, 2026-07-06
OMEGA	Fully local, SQLite + ONNX embeddings, zero external deps , MCP-native, AES-256 at rest	Yes	Simplest zero-dep local + MCP for coding agents	MCP.Directory

Episodic vs semantic: Letta = self-managed core (semantic, agent-editable) + archival (episodic search); mem0 = distilled semantic facts with mutation; Zep = temporal graph (episodic events → semantic facts with validity intervals).

Recommendation for HelixMemory: - **Primary durable store: Zep/Graphiti** — its temporal graph is the right substrate for a coding platform where facts change

over time (a function's signature, a config value, "the bug we fixed last week"). This aligns with Helix's SQLite-SSoT + history discipline (§11.4.93/§11.4.95) at the *agent* layer. - **Extraction/convenience layer: mem0** — 5-line integration for per-session fact capture; or **OMEGA** if zero-dependency + MCP-native local is preferred for the CLI coding agents. - **Expose via MCP**: run the memory server as an MCP server (add/search/update) so Claude Code / OpenCode / Qwen / Crush all reach it uniformly (mirrors §11.4.78 CodeGraph MCP wiring). Keep it **project-agnostic** (§11.4.28) — the consumer registers namespaces at runtime.

Caveat (§11.4.6): LongMemEval numbers above are from secondary blogs quoting the Zep paper; verify against the primary Zep/Graphiti evaluation before treating 63.8 vs 49.0 as canonical.

6. Serving + rootless Podman

6.1 Serving engines

- **TEI (HF text-embeddings-inference)** — purpose-built for embeddings/rerankers (short fixed inputs, no KV cache, vector outputs); **lowest latency**, serves embeddings **and** rerankers. **Primary** engine. ([Spheron, 2026-07-06](#); [kunwar.page ch.49, 2026-07-06](#))
- **Infinity** — one server hosting **many** models at once (embeddings + rerankers + ColBERT/ColPali + CLIP), **OpenAI-compatible** API, backends **PyTorch** / **ONNX** / **TensorRT** / **CTranslate2**; explicitly supports BGE + Jina (embed & rerank) and decoder Qwen2 embedders. Use when you need **multi-model** or ColBERT/multi-vector. ([Infinity GitHub, 2026-07-06](#))
- **vLLM** — highest **throughput** for large decoder-based embedders and for co-serving the generation LLM; v0.11.0 **natively supports Blackwell/RTX 5090** (NVFP4/CUTLASS). Use for big-batch offline indexing or when the embedder is a 7B+ decoder. ([Snowflake/vLLM embeddings, 2026-07-06](#); [allenkuo Blackwell, 2026-07-06](#))

Throughput/latency summary from sources: **vLLM** leads raw throughput; **TEI** leads latency; specialised servers (Arctic/BEI) beat both on throughput. ([Snowflake, 2026-07-06](#); [Baseten BEI, 2026-07-06](#))

6.2 RTX 5090 / Blackwell notes

- **32 GB GDDR7 @ ~1.79 TB/s**; runs 32B-class at Q4 on one card. ([MadCoolStuff, 2026-07-06](#))
- Needs **recent CUDA (12.8+/13.x)** + **driver 580+** for full Blackwell/FP8/FP4 kernels; some quant libs needed Blackwell patches through early 2026 (mostly closed by mid-2026). ([arXiv 2601.09527, 2026-07-06](#); [allenkuo, 2026-07-06](#))

- **VRAM budgeting on one 5090:** the generation LLM will dominate. Keep embedders small: Qwen3-Embedding-4B (~8 GB) + bge-reranker-v2-m3 (~1 GB) + BGE-M3 (~2 GB) ≈ **11 GB** for the retrieval tier, leaving ~20 GB for a quantized code LLM. If co-hosting a large LLM, drop to **Qwen3-Embedding-0.6B** (~1.5 GB) or move indexing to CPU/off-peak.

6.3 Rootless Podman + GPU (CDI)

The correct 2026 path is **CDI (Container Device Interface)** via the NVIDIA Container Toolkit — the recommended, rootless-friendly mechanism. ([NVIDIA CDI docs, 2026-07-06](#); [Podman Desktop GPU, 2026-07-06](#); [OneUptime, 2026-07-06](#))

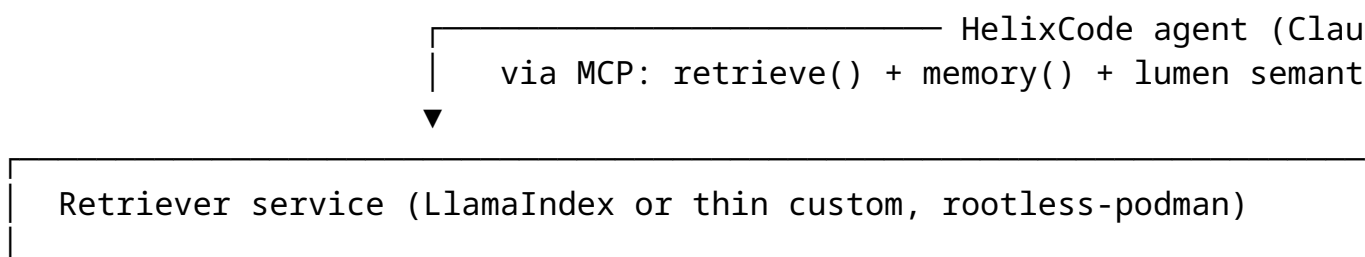
```
# 1. Generate a CDI spec (rootless: into the user config dir)
mkdir -p ~/.config/cdi
nvidia-ctk cdi generate --output=$HOME/.config/cdi/nvidia.yaml
# (system-wide alternative: sudo nvidia-ctk cdi generate --
#   output=/etc/cdi/nvidia.yaml)
# Toolkit >= v1.18.0 auto-refreshes via the nvidia-cdi-refresh
#   systemd unit.
```

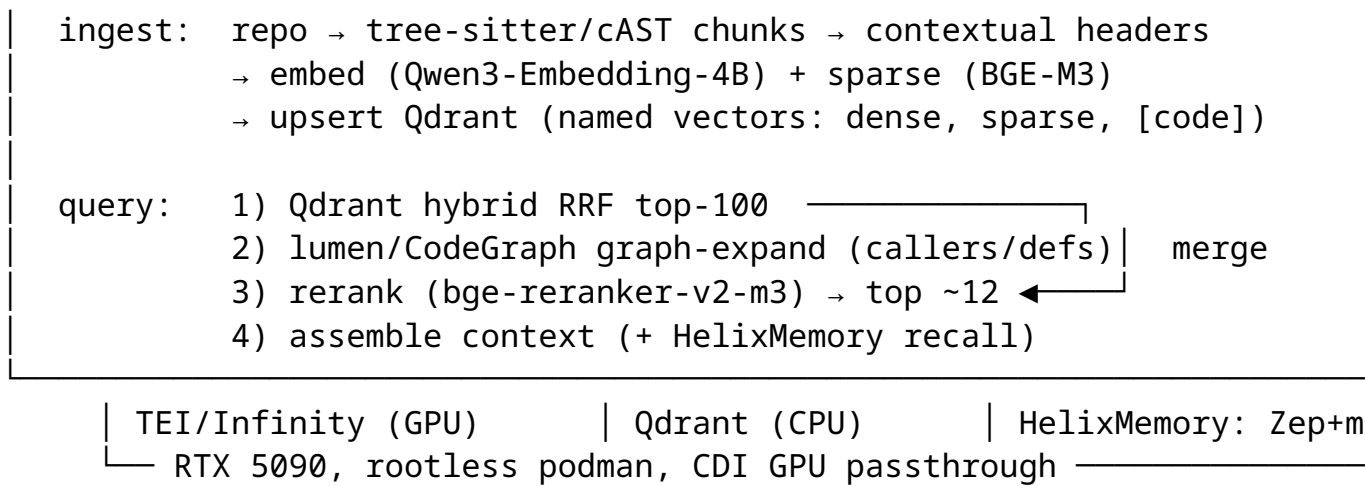
```
# 2. Run a GPU container rootless (Podman >= 4.1 supports --
#   device CDI refs)
```

```
podman run --rm \
--device nvidia.com/gpu=all \
--security-opt=label=disable \
ghcr.io/huggingface/text-embeddings-inference:latest \
--model-id Qwen/Qwen3-Embedding-4B
```

- Aligns with Helix §11.4.161 **rootless-container mandate** and §11.4.76 **containers submodule** — drive boot/health through the containers submodule's pkg/boot/pkg/compose, not ad-hoc podman run, in the real deployment.
- Per-service containers: tei-embed, tei-rerank (or one infinity container hosting both + code embedder), qdrant, helixmemory (zep/mem0), on a shared rootless pod network. Qdrant needs **no GPU**.

7. Reference architecture sketch (code-RAG)





Data flow: AST chunk → contextual-embed → hybrid store → hybrid recall → graph-fuse → rerank → assemble → agent. Memory writes (episodic facts, resolved bugs, decisions) go to Zep/Graphiti; memory reads join the context assembly step.

8. Top 3 risks

- Blackwell / sm_120 toolchain drift.** Quant kernels, TEI/Infinity/vLLM builds, and some embedders needed CUDA 12.8+/13.x + driver 580+ and Blackwell patches; a mismatched image silently falls back to slow paths or fails to load FP8/FP4. **Mitigation:** pin CUDA 13.x base images, driver ≥580, test each container’s `nvidia-smi` + a real embed call before trusting it (§11.4.108 runtime signature). ([arXiv 2601.09527](#))
 - VRAM contention on a single 32 GB card.** A large code LLM + embedder + reranker + big-batch indexing can OOM. **Mitigation:** size embedders down (4B or 0.6B), run heavy re-indexing off-peak or on CPU, cap batch sizes; consider a second index pass rather than co-resident everything.
 - License traps + benchmark over-trust.** Several **Jina embedding/reranker weights are CC-BY-NC** (not for commercial self-host); and headline MTEB/LongMemEval numbers come from secondary blogs. **Mitigation:** ship only Apache-2.0/MIT weights (Qwen3, BGE, Stella, nomic, mxbai); verify every headline number against the model card / primary paper before pinning (§11.4.6/§11.4.99). Secondary risks: rerank latency added to every query (budget it), and code-chunking edge cases (giant files, generated code) — validate cAST output on the real repo.
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Sources verified 2026-07-06

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- kunwar.page — Ch.49 TEI for embeddings & rerankers in production — <https://www.kunwar.page/chapter/049-tei-for-embeddings-and-rerankers-in-production>
- Infinity (michaelfeil) — embedding/reranker/ColBERT server — <https://github.com/michaelfeil/infinity>
- Snowflake/vLLM — Scaling vLLM for Embeddings (16x) — <https://www.snowflake.com/en/engineering-blog/embedding-inference-arctic-16x-faster/>
- Baseten — How we built BEI (high-throughput embed/rerank) — <https://www.baseten.co/blog/how-we-built-bei-high-throughput-embedding-inference/>

- cAST — Structural Chunking via AST (arXiv 2506.15655) — <https://arxiv.org/abs/2506.15655>
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